Lesson 05 material: Parallelism

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

2.4: Parallelism

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Learning Objectives

1. Identify sentences that are parallel and not parallel.
2. Identify ways to create parallelism in writing.
3. Write and revise sentences using parallelism.

Earlier in this chapter, we learned that increasing sentence variety adds interest to a piece of writing and makes the reading process more enjoyable for others. Using a mixture of sentence lengths and patterns throughout an essay is an important writing technique. However, it is equally important to avoid introducing variation within individual sentences. A strong sentence is composed of balanced parts that all have the same structure. In this section, we will examine how to create a balanced sentence structure by using parallelism.

Using Parallelism

Parallelism is the use of similar structure in related words, clauses, or phrases. It creates a sense of rhythm and balance within a sentence. As readers, we often correct faulty parallelism — a lack of parallel structure — intuitively because an unbalanced sentence sounds awkward and poorly constructed. Read the following sentences aloud:

Faulty parallelism: Kelly had to iron, do the washing, and shopping before her parents arrived.

Faulty parallelism: Driving a car requires coordination, patience, and to have good eyesight.

Faulty parallelism: Ali prefers jeans to wearing a suit.

All of these sentences contain faulty parallelism. Although they are factually correct, the construction is clunky and confusing. In the first example, three different verb forms are used. In the second and third examples, the writer begins each sentence by using a noun (*coordination*, *jeans*), but ends with a phrase (*to have good eyesight*, *wearing a suit*). Now read the same three sentences that have correct parallelism.

Correct parallelism: Kelly had to do the ironing, washing, and shopping before her parents arrived.

Correct parallelism: Driving a car requires coordination, patience, and good eyesight.

Correct parallelism: Ali prefers wearing jeans to wearing a suit.

When these sentences are written using a parallel structure, they sound more aesthetically pleasing because they are balanced. Repetition of grammatical construction also minimizes the amount of work the reader has to do to decode the sentence. This enables the reader to focus on the main idea in the sentence and not on how the sentence is put together.

Tip

A simple way to check for parallelism in your writing is to make sure you have paired nouns with nouns, verbs with verbs, prepositional phrases with prepositional phrases, and so on. Underline each element in a sentence and check that the corresponding element uses the same grammatical form.

Creating Parallelism Using Coordinating Conjunctions

When you connect two clauses using a coordinating conjunction (*for*, *and*, *nor*, *but*, *or*, *yet*, *so*), make sure that the same grammatical structure is used on each side of the conjunction. Take a look at the following example:

Faulty parallelism: When I walk the dog, I like **to listen to music** and **talking to friends** on the phone.

Correct parallelism: When I walk the dog, I like **listening to music** and **talking to friends** on the phone.

The first sentence uses two different verb forms (*to listen*, *talking*). In the second sentence, the grammatical construction on each side of the coordinating conjunction (*and*) is the same, creating a parallel sentence. The same technique should be used for joining items or lists in a series:

Faulty parallelism: This committee needs to decide whether the company should **reduce its workforce, cut its benefits,** or **lowering workers' wages**.

Correct parallelism: This committee needs to decide whether the company should **reduce its workforce, cut its benefits,** or **lower workers' wages**.

The first sentence contains two items that use the same verb construction (*reduce*, *cut*) and a third item that uses a different verb form (*lowering*). The second sentence uses the same verb construction in all three items, creating a parallel structure.

Exercise :

On your own sheet of paper, revise each of the following sentences to create parallel structure using coordinating conjunctions.

1. Mr. Koirla enjoys reading and to play his guitar on weekends.
2. The doctor told Mrs. Hall that she should either eat less or should exercise more.
3. Breaking out of the prison compound, the escapees moved carefully, quietly, and were quick on their feet.

4. I have read the book, but I have not watched the movie version.
5. Deal with a full inbox first thing in the morning, or by setting aside short periods of time in which to answer e-mail queries.

Creating Parallelism Using Than or As

When you are making a comparison, the two items being compared should have a parallel structure. Comparing two items without using parallel structure can lead to confusion about what is being compared. Comparisons frequently use the words *than* or *as*, and the items on each side of these comparison words should be parallel. Take a look at the following example:

Faulty parallelism: Swimming in the ocean is much tougher than **a pool**.

Correct parallelism: Swimming in the ocean is much tougher than **swimming in a pool**.

In the first sentence, the elements before the comparison word (*than*) are not equal to the elements after the comparison word. It appears that the writer is comparing an action (*swimming*) with a noun (*a pool*). In the second sentence, the writer uses the same grammatical construction to create a parallel structure. This clarifies that an action is being compared with another action.

To correct some instances of faulty parallelism, it may be necessary to add or delete words in a sentence.

Faulty parallelism: A brisk walk is as beneficial to your health as **going for a run**.

Correct parallelism: Going for a brisk walk is as beneficial to your health as **going for a run**.

In this example, it is necessary to add the verb phrase *going for* to the sentence in order to clarify that the act of walking is being compared to the act of running.

Exercise :

On your own sheet of paper, revise each of the following sentences to create parallel structure using than or as .

1. I would rather work at a second job to pay for a new car than a loan.
2. How you look in the workplace is just as important as your behavior.
3. The firefighter spoke more of his childhood than he talked about his job.
4. Indian cuisine is far tastier than the food of Great Britain.
5. Amber's opponent was as tall as Amber and he carried far more weight.

Creating Parallelism Using Correlative Conjunctions

A correlative conjunction is a paired conjunction that connects two equal parts of a sentence and shows the relationship between them. Common correlative conjunctions include the following:

- either…or
- not only…but also
- neither…nor
- whether…or
- rather…than
- both…and

Correlative conjunctions should follow the same grammatical structure to create a parallel sentence. Take a look at the following example:

Faulty parallelism: We can neither **wait** for something to happen nor **can we take** evasive action.

Correct parallelism: We can neither **wait** for something to happen nor **take** evasive action.

When using a correlative conjunction, the words, phrases, or clauses following each part should be parallel. In the first sentence, the construction of the second part of the sentence does not match the construction of the first part. In the second sentence, omitting needless words and matching verb constructions create a parallel structure. Sometimes, rearranging a sentence corrects faulty parallelism.

Faulty parallelism: It was both a long movie and poorly written.

Correct parallelism: The movie was both long and poorly written

Tip

This is an area where we see mistakes. To see examples of parallelism in use, read some of the great historical speeches by rhetoricians such as Abraham Lincoln and Martin Luther King Jr. Notice how they use parallel structures to emphasize important points and to create a smooth, easily understandable oration.

Here is a link to text, audio, video, and the music of Martin Luther King's speech "I Have a Dream": http://www.mlkonline.net/dream.html

Note that the spelling and grammar checker on most word processors will not draw attention to faulty parallelism. When proofreading a document, read it aloud and listen for sentences that sound awkward or poorly phrased.

Exercise :

On your own sheet of paper, revise each of the following sentences to create parallel structure using correlative conjunctions.

1. The cyclist owns both a mountain bike and has a racing bike.
2. The movie not only contained lots of action, but also it offered an important lesson.
3. My current job is neither exciting nor is it meaningful.

4. Antonio would rather listen to his father than be taking advice from me.
5. We are neither interested in buying a vacuum cleaner nor do we want to utilize your carpet cleaning service.

Exercise :

Read through the following excerpt from Alex's essay and revise any instances of faulty parallelism. Rewrite the sentences to create a parallel structure.

Figure

Key Takeaways

- Parallelism creates a sense of rhythm and balance in writing by using the same grammatical structure to express equal ideas.
- Faulty parallelism occurs when elements of a sentence are not balanced, causing the sentence to sound clunky and awkward.
- Parallelism may be created by connecting two clauses or making a list using coordinating conjunctions; by comparing two items using *than* or *as*; or by connecting two parts of a sentence using correlative conjunctions.

Links on the original page

- Web page (mlkonline.net): http://www.mlkonline.net/dream.html

2.11: Parallel Structure

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

What is parallel structure?

As you may know, parallel lines are two lines that continue without ever touching (see Figure 2.10.1). Parallel structure is similar. It is two separate grammar structures that exist side by side in your writing.

(Picture: a set of railroad tracks running in parallel lines)

Figure: Parallel railroad tracks ("Parallel Lines" by Ko:(char *)hook is licensed under CC BY-NC 2.0)

Parallel structure means using the same pattern of words to show that two or more ideas have the same level of importance. This results in clearer and more consistent writing, which helps readers better understand your point. We are focusing on parallel structure for two reasons. First of all, you may have errors to fix. However, if you use it correctly, it is a powerful tool for improving cohesion.

Parallel structure and cohesion

Parallel structure increases cohesion by showing your reader how ideas are connected together.

Try this!

Let's look at some quotes by public figures that have parallel structure. Can you make a guess at how they end?

1. “Not everything that is faced can be changed. But nothing can be changed until it is ...."—James Baldwin
2. “If you want others to be happy, practice compassion. If you want to be happy, practice ....” —The Dalai Lama
3. “We must accept finite disappointment, but never lose infinite...” —Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr.
4. “Success is getting what you want. Happiness is wanting .....” —Dale Carnegie
5. "People will forget what you said, people will forget what you did, but people will never forget how you made them ....." —Maya Angelou
6. “We make a living by what we get, but we make a life by what .....” —Winston Churchill
7. "To be smart on crime, we should not be in a position of constantly reacting to crime after it happens. We should be looking at preventing crime ....." —Kamala Harris
8. "I just hope that more people will ignore the fatalism of the argument that we are beyond repair. We are not beyond repair. We are never ....." —Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez
9. “Ask not what your country can do for you; ask what....” —John F. Kennedy

(To see the complete quotation, check the 2.15: Answer Key: Organization and Cohesion)

As you can see, it was easier to guess and remember the quotations because they use parallel structure. Would anyone remember a quotation like "Ask not what your country can do for you. Instead, why don't you think about whether there is anything that you can do to help improve your nation"? Probably not.

In paragraphs, we can see the same thing. We can understand complex ideas more clearly if there is parallel structure that shows us how they are connected.

Types of parallel structure

We can use parallel structure for single words up through entire clauses. Let's see how that works.

Parallel structure with words

If you are listing words, make sure that all of the words are the same part of speech.

Incorrect parallel structure: Stereotypes are inevitable and problems.

Here, you have an adjective and a noun. The reader will get a little lost in the reading because they will not understand the connection between these words. You can fix it by making both words into adjectives.

Improved parallel structure: Stereotypes are inevitable and problematic.

Parallel structure with verbs

If you are using two or more verbs that are part of a list, that are connected by a conjunction, or that come after another verb, make sure they are the same form and tense.

Incorrect parallel structure: I hate to make stereotypes about others and hearing others making stereotypes about me.

You can use either a gerund or an infinitive after the verb "hate", but you should choose the same form for both verbs.

Improved parallel structure: I hate making stereotypes about others and hearing others making stereotypes about me.

Parallel structure with phrases and clauses

If you are using two or more phrases or clauses that are part of a list or comparison or that are linked by a conjunction, make sure they follow the same structure. This will make it easier for readers to understand the connection between your idea.

Incorrect parallel structure: There is a lot of discussion about what women experience when they are studying science and engineering and better supporting them.

This sentence confusing for the reader because the objects of the preposition "about" are long and have different structures. To make it more clear, the same structure can be used for both. For example, making them both noun clauses that start with "wh" quesetion words will make the relationship more clear.

Improved parallel structure: There is a lot of discussion about what women experience while studying science and engineering and how universities can better support them.

Identifying parallel structure

Let's see how published writers use parallel structure to make complex sentences and ideas more clear for the reader.

Notice this!

Here is a paragraph from a published research paper by on women in engineering by Kathleen N. Smith and Joy Gaston Gayles. It has a variety of sentence structures. Can you find examples of parallel structure of words, phrases, or clauses?

Why is it that women who are talented in math and science avoid or leave engineering majors and careers? An American Association of University Women report on women's success in engineering and computing suggests that women who persist in science and engineering are not all that different from women who decide to leave. The major difference between staying and leaving has been found to have less to do with the women themselves and more to do with the academic and workplace environments where they attend school and pursue careers. Throughout the literature on women's persistence in science, technology, engineering, and math (STEM) fields, a range of structural and cultural barriers contribute to the high prevalence of gender bias in these fields, with direct implications for women's self-efficacy, experiences, opportunities, and success, particularly in engineering.

(For possible answers, check the 2.15: Answer Key: Organization and Cohesion)

Fixing errors with parallel structure

Here are some tips for improving your parallel structure:

Articles and prepositions

Articles (*a*, *an*, *the*) and prepositions (*of, in, by, at*, etc.) in a list should either be used only once or be repeated with each term:

- Faulty parallelism: **The** science fields, **the** technology fields, and engineering fields.
  - Correction: **The** science fields, **the** technology fields, and **the** engineering fields.
  - Alternate correction: **The** science fields, technology fields, and engineering fields.
- Faulty parallelism: **In** elementary school, high school, or **in** college.
  - Correction: **In** elementary school, **in** high school, or **in** college.
  - Alternate correction: **In** elementary school, high school, or college.

Correlative expressions

Correlative expressions are phrases that are used to connect structures together. However, sometimes they are used incorrectly. Here are some tips:

- "not only" requires a "but also"
- "either" requires an "or"
- "neither" requires a "nor"
- say "first, second, third, etc." or ("firstly, secondly, thirdly," etc.)

Here are some examples:

- Faulty parallelism: It was **neither** helpful or useful.
  - Corrected version: It was **neither** helpful **nor** useful.
- Faulty parallelism: It was **not only** a long class, it was boring.
  - Corrected version: **Not only** was the class long, **but** it was **also** boring.
- Faulty parallelism: **First**, I will explain the problem. **Secondly**, I will offer a solution.
  - Corrected version: **First**, I will explain the problem. **Second**, I will offer a solution.

Add parallel structure for clarity and cohesion

As your essay, look at each sentence in your draft and check to see if you have problems with the parallel structure or if more parallel structure can make the relationship between ideas stronger.

Try this!

Here are three sentences from a student's body paragraph. How can you improve the parallel structure?

- Having stereotypes highlights people's differences and equality is nearly impossible. In her TED talk, Chimimanda Adichie claims, "The consequence of the single story is this: it robs people dignity. . . . It emphasizes how we are different rather than how we are similar."
- What she means is that a single story usually focuses on what other groups do not have and it benefits the people telling the story, rather than the entire truth.
- This makes us look at our differences and society is less equal.

(For possible answers, check the 2.15: Answer Key: Organization and Cohesion)

Works Cited

Smith, Kathleen N., and Joy Gaston Gayles. "'Girl Power': Gendered Academic and Workplace Experiences of College Women in Engineering." *Social Sciences* 7.1 (2018): 11. *Crossref*. Web.

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Links on the original page

- Technical Writing at LBCC's page Parallel Contruction: https://openoregon.pressbooks.pub/lbcctechwriting/chapter/8-7-parallel-construction/
- "Girl Power": Gendered Academic and Workplace Experiences of College Women in Engineering": https://www.mdpi.com/2076-0760/7/1/11/htm